

The Partisan and Ideological Structure of Local Campaign Contributions

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Abstract

This paper catalogs the partisan and ideological nature of campaign contributions in city council and mayoral elections in mid-sized and large American cities. I show that local elections typically feature less within-contest partisan and ideological separation among donors than state legislative elections. I argue that this finding is a byproduct of the lack of opposite-party competition within local elections, not that partisanship is unimportant in local elections: when local elections feature competition in between a Democrat and a Republican instead of two co-partisans or higher levels of candidate ideological separation, donors tend to separate more along partisan and ideological divisions, holding city-wide attributes fixed. In an extension, I use individual-level data to assess if occupation-based groups constrain party-based giving under intra-party and inter-party competition. In intra-partisan settings, employment-based group preferences better explain contributory behavior than party-based group preferences. However, this relationship flips when contests feature inter-party competition. Taken together, these results suggest that partisanship and ideology are important, but conditional, drivers of preferences in local elections.

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A dominant strand of research in local politics argues that local politics are fundamentally distinct from national politics. While national politics is dominated by ideology and partisanship, the key players in local elections are motivated by their ties to local government and the local economy. However, a growing body of both observational and experimental work argues that individuals incorporate partisan and ideological cues into their preferences over candidates.

Using an original dataset on campaign contributions in 1810 American city council and mayoral elections, this paper considers the coexistence of these two literatures. I first document the partisan and ideological¹ nature of contributions in local elections. I find that in the typical local contest, donors to both candidates are not meaningfully separated along partisan or ideological lines. For donors, the correlation between industry and candidate choice is stronger than that between partisanship and candidate choice. That said, substantial variation exists: in about 11% of municipal contests, donors are as ideologically separated as the median state legislative contest.

When aggregated at the city level, substantial heterogeneity remains. I find that the latent dimension of contributions within a city is moderately correlated with measures of donor separation by ideology and partisanship, and candidate preferences in national elections. In some cities and contests, elections are highly structured by partisanship and ideology. In other instances, partisanship and ideology hold no explanatory power in describing donor preferences in general elections.

I leverage variation in differences in candidate partisanship and ideology in order to assess why some contests seem to be more driven by partisan and ideological factors. Within a city, I find that when the two candidates come from different parties, donors are substantially more separated along partisan and ideological lines. In fact, when a contest features inter-party competition, individuals tend to contribute alongside their party instead of their occupational group. Findings about the strength and weakness of national forces over preferences in local elections can coexist because the conditions associated with partisan-separated elections are not the norm in local elections: a little over a third of contests in my dataset feature inter-

¹In this paper, “ideology” refers to national left-right ideology.

party competition, and in the absence of inter-party competition, employment group-based cues better predict an individual's preferences over candidates.

Local politics as distinctive

One perspective characterizes city dynamics as distinctive from those found at the state and federal level. Two key findings contribute to the characterization.

First, in local elections, participation is overwhelmingly driven by those with material interests, such as homeowners, retired individuals, business owners and interest groups (Anzia, 2022; Einstein et al., 2026; Kirkland, 2022; Oliver & Ha, 2007; Yoder, 2020). Since cities set property and business taxes, run specialized programs for seniors, and act as an employer, numerous types of groups have substantial financial motivations to influence city policies. When these groups see their favored candidate win election, they are rewarded with favorable policies (Carreri et al., 2025; Kirkland, 2021), and this mechanism is further aided by the low-turnout, low-information nature of local elections (Anzia, 2011, 2013). These findings are in contrast to a key result on federal elections, where stakeholders seemingly under-participate (Ansolabehere et al., 2003).

The second is that personal candidate characteristics are important. This could be because cities are typically smaller than congressional and state legislative districts, thereby allowing for more direct personal relationships in between candidates and the community, or because information about the political beliefs and preferences of candidates is sparse. Vote choice has been shown to be related to personal acquaintance (Oliver & Ha, 2007) and valence (Kuriwaki, 2026).

If these factors are disproportionately important at the local level, this may imply that the role of partisanship and ideology are of reduced importance. In fact, Oliver and Ha (2007) finds that alignment with candidate stances trump party affiliation when suburban residents vote for local office, and minority-party candidates are more successful at winning office at the local level (Butler et al., 2025; Schaffner et al., 2007).

The role of partisanship in local politics

Of course, local interests are not entirely divorced from national partisanship and ideology (Jensen et al., 2021). When local issues, such as education and policing, gain nationwide prominence, individuals respond in ways consistent with ideological considerations (Gaudette, 2025; Reckhow et al., 2017).

In an experimental setting, Kirkland and Coppock (2018) conclude that the individual decision-making process is different when individuals choose in between candidates with and without partisan labels, and Dowling et al. (2025) use cast vote records from South Carolina and find that the addition of partisan labels indeed structures vote choice. These findings suggest that at the very least, voters consider partisanship to be a useful heuristic. Studies within a limited number of cities further argue that ideology, not just partisanship, matter in city politics, finding that voters develop an impression of a “left” and a “right” candidate, and use these evaluations in deciding who to vote for (Holman & Lay, 2021; Sances, 2018).

Just how partisan and nationalized is behavior in local elections? The role of partisanship in local elections has been recently challenged in Conevska et al. (2026). Using data from cast vote records from the November 2020 election, they find that voters’ up-ballot decisions are highly correlated with partisan down-ballot decisions, but that the correlation is much weaker when races are formally nonpartisan. They explain this by saying that *“the top two candidates in many of these races probably have similar ideologies, party affiliations, and national policies. But even when this is not the case, voters might care more about candidates’ positions on local issues...rather than on candidates’ ideologies, party affiliations, and positions on national policies”* (p7).

Since local elections are typically characterized as low-information settings, one concern is that voters may heuristically use party cues to vote, but that these decisions are unrelated to policy decisions. The partisanship of elected officials does seem to be meaningful in under certain circumstances (Burnett, 2019; de Benedictis-Kessner & Warshaw, 2016, 2020; Einstein & Glick, 2018; Einstein & Kogan, 2016; Tausanovitch & Warshaw, 2014). However, this is not uniformly the case (Ferreira & Gyourko, 2009, 2023; Gerber & Hopkins, 2011;

Thompson, 2020).

Can partisanship and local interests both be dominant forces in local politics?

The literature on interests and partisanship are not necessarily in conflict with each other. As indicated by the above Conevska et al. (2026) quote, low levels of partisan separation in local elections can indicate a lack of within-contest partisan competition within a substantial proportion of elections, or it may further indicate that individuals do not care about candidate partisanship in the absence of partisan labels. Without information about candidate ideology and party, these explanations implicate opposite importance to partisanship in local elections, even though they are observationally similar. I argue that the former explanation is correct and the latter incorrect. The majority of contests do not feature inter-party competition, and under intra-party competition, cues from local interests matter more to individuals. But when candidates differ on party, an individual’s own partisanship dominates.

Under formally partisan elections, down-ballot preferences are highly correlated with up-ballot preferences (Conevska et al., 2026; Dowling et al., 2025). This finding is compatible with many explanations about the importance of partisanship in local elections: individuals indeed care about candidate party, parties themselves are more active in local elections, formally partisan elections occur in hyper-polarized cities, formally partisan elections occur where cleavages across local issues are highly correlated with those over national issues, or lower-information voters simply defer to candidate partisanship as a heuristic. The component absent from previous work is the ability to disentangle partisan competition from city-wide election regime, and to identify a setting where participation is intentional. Instead of relying on comparisons from cities with formally partisan against cities with formally nonpartisan elections (Bucchianeri, 2020; Conevska et al., 2026), or within-contest as labels vary (Dowling et al., 2025), I examine how donor coalitions change when competition is in between a Democrat and a Republican instead of two partisans, holding city fixed.

Restricting to within-city variation in contributions provides a hard test of the importance of partisanship in local elections. The within-city variation strips out cross-sectional

explanatory power from attributes that may be correlated with resisting reform-era non-partisan election policies. Since variation may only come from formally non-partisan cities,² partisanship is not necessarily cued and may plausibly not be central to the contest or even widely known. Further, if contributions are a means that members of local interests use to exert influence, these contributions may further crowd out contributions from donors with partisan motivations. As a result, if donors interpret and act on partisan signals in formally nonpartisan elections, this certainly suggests that partisanship is a central concern.

Data

Campaign contributions are a valuable tool for studying the dynamics of individual-level participation and preferences. At the federal and state level, contributions are the primary data source used to jointly scale the ideology of federal and state candidates (Bonica, 2014). While voter behavior is the most common tool for studying electoral behavior across all levels of government, campaign contributions are of interest for several reasons.

Since campaign contributions are public information, I am able to link a donor’s identity to their behavior and their preferences. Contribution records typically report donor name, employment (often both occupation and employer), address, and the recipient of funds. It is possible to link individual-level participation and preferences across various domains. In this paper, I link municipal donors to voter files and to congressional contribution data. This is a meaningful improvement over costly survey data and over analyzing voting using observational data, where it is only possible to observe de-anonymized participation binaries (turning out in an election), or anonymized preferences (from cast vote records). Contributions may come from organizations, who cannot vote but often have a serious interest in the outcomes of local policy.³ Since contributions are costly, they represent participation and preferences from individuals and groups invested in electoral outcomes. When this in-

²To the best of my knowledge, no cities switched between non-partisan and partisan elections within the data. Variation in ideology comes from both formally partisan and non-partisan cities, but results subsetting on only non-partisan cities are similar.

³While these contributions are relatively rare (only about 8% of local contributions come from organizations), their median contribution amounts to \$500, well above the median individual contribution of \$150.

formation is combined, campaign contributions offer view of local politics where candidate, individual (or organizational), and race-level attributes and preferences are observed with high confidence.

Dataset on campaign contributions in local elections

The core dataset for this paper is an original dataset on contributions to local city elections. I primarily collect data on city council and mayoral races since these roles have lawmaking powers and have quasi-analogs within state and federal levels. While the competitiveness, power, and method of appointment differ across cities (for example, some mayors are appointed), city councilors and mayors are generally elected lawmaking officials. Non-lawmaking administrative positions such as city clerk are not consistently elected positions, and other seats typically examined within the political science literature, such as school board, superintendent, and law enforcement, are not consistently elected at the city level.

This paper starts with a dataset of over 5.5 million contributions to local elections from over 200 cities. The inclusion and exclusion of certain cities within this dataset is not random. A city's inclusion within this dataset primarily concerns three considerations: population, data availability, and cost.

First, I use a population threshold of 100,000 to initially select cases. I look into collecting data from each city with a population over 100,000. The volume of campaign contributions substantially drops off as city population declines,⁴ so any analysis on money in local elections will necessarily be weighted towards the politics of mid-sized and larger cities. Though the data in this paper does not describe the state of all cities in the United States, cities above this threshold are meaningful. About 29% of Americans live in cities with populations above 100,000 and many more commute into these cities to work. My sample not only captures major economic centers and most state capitals, but also a substantial amount of suburbs to major cities. A key feature of contributions is that donors need not reside where they

⁴In most cities, candidates who raise less than a certain threshold (typically in the single-thousands) and/or have no itemizable donors (itemization thresholds per donor are typically in the \$100-200 range) are not required to report campaign contributions, even if they do in fact raise cash. However, these cases are not observable.

donate, though in practice, most contributions are from the city or surrounding areas.

Limited data availability across time and space explains some missingness. There is no national repository of municipal campaign contributions. Few states have centralized campaign contribution databases. I prioritized cities where I could obtain at least three cycles' worth of data, and this was not always possible. For example, despite being home to 42 cities with populations above 100,000, Texas only compels municipalities to maintain campaign finance reports for two years after filing, and many cities do not maintain reports past these two mandatory years.⁵ In other cases, cities were unresponsive to my open records requests.

A third reason for city inclusion and exclusion is data costs. While the largest cities are increasingly fully digitizing new campaign contribution data, many cities still fully or partially provide scanned copies of campaign contribution reports. Cities may charge fees associated with finding and scanning these records. While scanned copies of printed reports are generally legible with the use of optical character recognition software, handwritten forms remain difficult to process computationally. In some cases, I hired a research assistant to transcribe handwritten forms, but I was not able to do this for all eligible cities.

While the data collection centered around larger (primarily population over 100k) cities, some smaller cities are present within this analysis and within the broader dataset for two reasons. Some states, such as Delaware, have no cities with over 100,000 residents, and in such cases, I collect data on the state capital or most populous city when possible. In other cases, municipal campaign contributions data is available at a level above the city level (e.g. statewide in Washington, county-wide in Michigan's Wayne County, and assorted California cities use a finance management system named Netfile). In these cases, I do use data from select cities with populations above 50,000 within this paper's analyses.

Dataset components

I combine an original dataset on campaign contributions in American cities with various other datasets. My base dataset (before dropping cases due to non-matching) comprises over

⁵<https://www.cedarparktexas.gov/412/Campaign-Finance-Reports-Form-C-OH>

5.5 million contributions from cities in nearly 40 states. Cities that are used in this analysis are mapped in Appendix Figure 8 and are listed in Appendix 1.2. Rows in this database feature donor name, address, occupation, contribution amount, and recipient, though not all fields are consistently reported. I combine this dataset with several additional datasets.

	Merges with:	
	Local contribs	State contribs (DIME)
Bonica (2014) – Cong contribs	Full name, zip (exact)	Bonica CID (exact)
L2 Voter file	Full name, zip (fuzzy)	Full name, zip (exact)
de Benedictis-Kessner et al. (2023)	Candidate, city, year (manual)	
Handan-Nader et al. (2026)		Bonica RID (exact)

Table 1 – Data Sources

Data sources and merging fields are outlined in Table 1. I start with my dataset on campaign contributions in mayoral and city council candidates. I merge my dataset with de Benedictis-Kessner et al. (2023)’s data on candidates and contest pairings in municipal general elections. To get donor party identification I match donors with the L2 voter files from February 2018. Further details on data sources and merging are in the below subsection.

I compare local contributions to contributions for state legislature seats, 2012-2018 in Figures 2-5. I use state legislative contribution data from Bonica (2014), merged to the February 2018 L2 voter file to obtain donor party identification. I merge this with election results from Handan-Nader et al. (2026) to obtain contest pairings in general elections .

Both of these datasets are then merged with congressional donor data from Bonica (2014) in order to calculate Hall and Snyder Jr (2015)-style scores for both state legislative and local candidates. Under this procedure, a candidate’s score is the dollar-weighted average of the DW-NOMINATE or Recipient CFScores of the congressional candidates their donors also support.

Merging and processing

Table 1 describes external merges. For fuzzy merges, I use a multi-step procedure based on full name (fuzzy)⁶ and zip code (exact). I first identify exact matches, where an individ-

⁶Many cities report donor full name instead of separate fields for first and last name.

ual’s L2/DIME first+middle+last or first+last perfectly match the campaign contribution record. If a record cannot be matched to the voter file exactly, I then employ a series of partial matches.⁷ After creating a series of partial matches, I use Ornstein (2026)’s *fuzzylink* to assess the likelihood that the names match.⁸ I retain only linkages that *fuzzylink* labels as matches.

I extract voter party identification from these matches. If a contribution is only linked to one individual in the voter file (about 97.15% of linked contributions), or if they are matched to multiple individuals within only one party (2.82%), I accept that party identification. In some instances, an individual (same age, address, and name) is double-registered in the voter file under different parties, usually in a major party and a minor party/independent. In these cases, I take the major party. I do not use ambiguous cases where a contribution is matched with both Republicans and Democrats.

Since the vast majority (about 90%) of these matches are from exact matches (local contributor full name = first+middle+last or first+last in the voter file), I use only these exact matches to link state contributions to the voter file and to link congressional contributions to the local donor dataset. I do not require that contributions to congressional candidate precede or follow the municipal contribution.

In the final section of this paper, I categorize donors by occupation group. Raw employer and occupation is a straightforward field, and I combine both into a singular string and categorize individuals based on the presence of key words as outlined in Appendix 1.1. Not all cities require that employment be publicly reported, and many candidates within cities with the requirement to report employment fail to do so. Of those with parse-able employer/occupation data, I am able to categorize about 88%. The distribution of industries is shown in Appendix Table 4.

⁷I put into consideration names with > 2 words with first-two-word matches and last-two-word matches, a sorted word match, a first initial and last word match, a first initial and second-to-last word match, a nickname exact first+middle+last or first+last match (from <https://github.com/carltonnorthern/nicknames/blob/master/names.csv>), and a Jaro-Winkler distance > 0.89.

⁸I use OpenAI’s GPT-5.4-nano model and block by contribution, so that the model does not attempt to resolve matching for non-possible linkages.

To link candidate attributes from de Benedictis-Kessner et al. (2023) to local contributions, I hand-merge candidate names (from de Benedictis-Kessner et al., 2023) to committee names in my dataset. After all merges, the primary dataset used in this paper encompasses 1.6 million contributions and 1810 unique contests across 156 cities in 37 states. About 639k records include industry categories and 608k include partisanship.

Measures

This subsection describes key dependent and independent variables used within this paper, taken from or calculated using the above sources.

Measures of donor behavior at the candidate level: The key descriptive task in this paper is to measure the partisan and ideological lean of local contributors. To measure the partisan lean of donor pools, I start with the percent of funds for each candidate coming from Democrats. For each candidate C_i within a contest, I calculate the proportion of C_i 's contributions from Democrats, over C_i 's contributions from Democrats and Republicans.⁹ This is the value in the top panel of Figure 1. To calculate the ideological bend of donor pools, I use a procedure similar to Hall and Snyder Jr (2015) to calculate the average scores of the congresspeople who municipal donors also contributed to, using both CFScores and DW-NOMINATE.¹⁰ I refer to these as imputed DW-NOMINATE and CFScores. The use of CFScores and DW-NOMINATE is beneficial not only because they are another (though correlated) dimension in addition to the by-party proportions, but also because it enables the use of data from non-individual donors. This value is used in the top panel of Figure 2.

Direct measures of candidate attributes: As a measure of a local candidate's own ideological positioning, I use Contributor CFScores from Bonica (2014), as reported in de Benedictis-Kessner et al. (2023). These are CFScores based on a candidate's own contributions to state and federal elections, and are independent of their own money-raising activity.

⁹For the purposes of this measure, unmatched and non-major party affiliated donors are not considered, but are considered in other measures.

¹⁰For example, if C_1 's donors also gave to Senator X and Representative Y, then C_1 's average donor ideology is the dollar-weighted average of X and Y's DW-NOMINATE or CFScores. To maintain consistency across both measures, I only use contributions to Members of Congress, since DW-NOMINATE only provides scores for sitting MoC.

Latent measure of candidate positioning: In Figure 3, I use correspondence analysis (CA) on the contribution matrix (values are $\log(x+1)$ dollars), within a given city, in order to compare the underlying distribution of campaign contributions to other measures of ideology and partisanship. For each city, I use CA on donors who have given at least three distinct candidates within city races (identified using an exact match on full name and zip code), and on candidates who have at least ten contributions from donors meeting this threshold. I extract the first dimension from the CA output, which positions each candidate along a latent axis, against other candidates within the same city.¹¹ This recovers a score per (eligible) candidate that can be compared to other candidate-side measures from the previous paragraph, or to aggregated donor behavior measures.

Contest-level measures: The remainder of the paper seeks to explain why some contests and cities experience higher levels of partisan-based giving by evaluating outcomes when competition is between same- and different-party candidates. Partisan competition (PC) within a contest takes on the value of 1 when contests are in between a Democrat and a Republican. PC is 0 when both candidates are from the same party. When one or both candidates’ partisan affiliation is indeterminate, observations are dropped. Candidate ideological differences are built by taking the absolute difference in Contributor CFScores (uncontaminated by local fundraising activity) from C_1 and C_2 . About 87% of contests include information about both candidates’ partisan affiliation. Around 39% of these occur in between a Republican and a Democrat. About 30% of contests have candidates where both have documented CFScores. Distributions are plotted in Figure 6. For the sake of clarity, “partisan competition” and “ideological competition” in this paper refer to contest-level characteristics about candidates, measured independently of donor behavior.

In order to determine the level of partisan and ideological giving, I create measures that encapsulate the level of partisan or ideological difference *among donors* within a given contest. I refer to these as partisan and ideological separation. I take the absolute difference between the percent of dollars originating from Democrats between the two candidates within

¹¹Sign is indeterminate in CA output, and when I compare CA output to ideological and partisan measures with a known direction, I take the by-city absolute value of the correlation.

a contest.¹² Similarly, I also take the absolute difference in imputed DW-NOMINATE, and in Figures 3-5, imputed CFScores under the same procedure.

Measures of contest-level group and party preferences: Table 3 uses measures of group and party unity for each contest. I calculate leave-one-out partisan and group unity for each donor within each contest for each contribution i . These measures take on value between 0 and 1, and reflect the proportion of funds within a contest allocated to Candidate 1 by Donor i 's fellow party members or individuals within the same employment category, excluding i 's own contribution.¹³ For Table 3, Figure 7, and Appendix Table 5, I subset to industry-contests and party-contests with a threshold of five or more donors. Appendix Figure 10 shows that the ordering of group unity is generally consistent across thresholds.

Partisan and ideological separation in local elections

Before incorporating measures on candidate partisanship, I first document heterogeneity in donor attributes at the candidate-contest and contest level. In this section, I report the proportion that a candidate raises from Democratic donors. I report the distribution of imputed CFScores, based on the preferences of local-congressional donors. For both measures, I chart the within-contest difference, which represent the degree of ideological and partisan separation among donors, and benchmark these values to distributions found in state legislative contests. Finally, I ask how these measures correlate with the latent dynamics of within-city campaign contributions. I find substantial heterogeneity across cities and contests. In some contests, donors are split (or indistinguishable) along partisan and ideological lines. In some cities, the latent dimension of contributions correlates highly (or poorly) with these measures of donor partisanship and ideology.

¹²This is mathematically equivalent to the absolute difference in the percent of dollars originating from Republicans, and is akin to a dollar-weighted computation of the Absolute Partisan Gap from Conevska et al. (2026).

¹³To short-circuit issues related to the interconnectedness of other individual's dependent variables serving as an independent variable, I also calculate group and party preferences using a 1/3 sample that is not used in the regression in Column 5. Results are similar.

Contributions are not particularly defined by a partisan split

I first consider the partisan split of campaign contributions. In the top panel of Figure 1, I categorize C_1 and C_2 by whether they are the candidate who receives a higher proportion of their funds from Democrats. This measure indicates the partisan divisions among each candidate’s donor pools, and does not reflect total imbalances in fundraising. Overall, most candidates have a majority of Democratic donors — unsurprising given the distribution of cities. Notably, the candidate with fewer Democratic donors seems mostly uniform throughout the range, while distribution from the candidate with higher levels of Democratic support has a strong skew, indicating that separation in backing certainly exists at times.

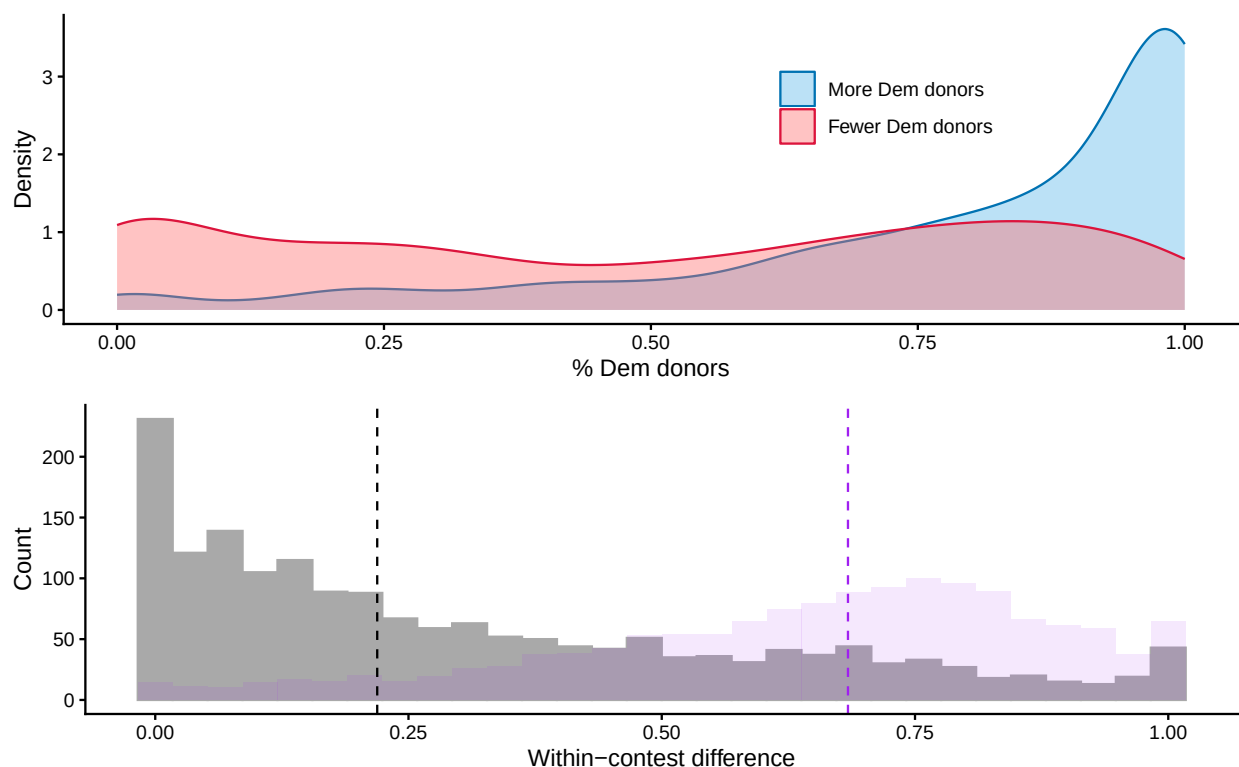


Figure 1 – The proportion of a candidate’s funds originating from Democrats (top panel), and the within-contest differences between candidates (bottom panel). For comparative purposes, the distribution of state legislature contributions are in light purple in the bottom panel.

For a clearer comparison of the separation in partisan backing, the lower panel of Figure 1 takes the difference within-contest. Concretely, if C_1 has only Democratic donors and if

45% of C_2 's funds come from Democrats, the within-contest difference is 0.55.¹⁴ Generally, within-contest differences in separation by donor partisanship are substantially lower than in state legislative races. On average, the partisan split in municipal races, charted in gray, is about 0.2. State legislative races have an average difference around 0.7, indicating substantially more within-contest separation at the state level. In local races, one candidate will typically raise somewhat more from a given party, but both candidates frequently raise the majority of their funds from donors within the same party.

Contests are not particularly defined by an ideological split

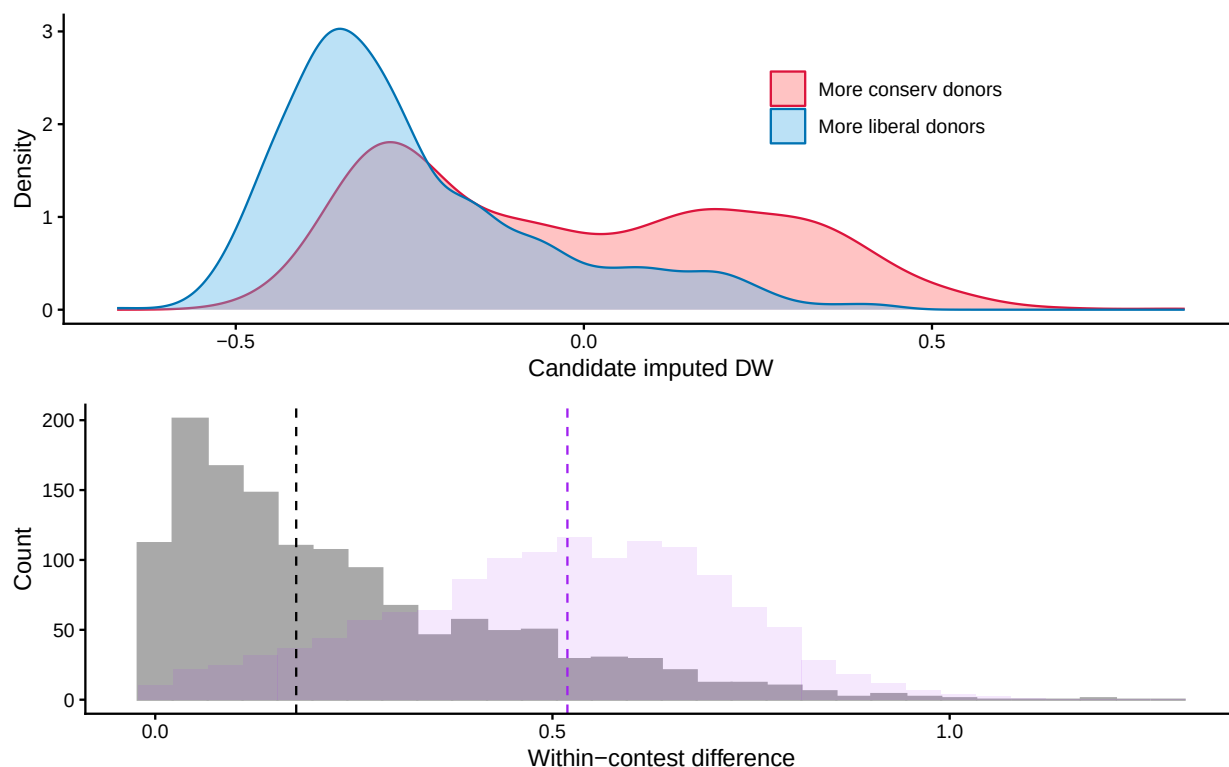


Figure 2 – The ideological distribution of local campaign contributions (above), and the within-contest differences between candidates (below). For comparative purposes, the distribution of state legislature contributions are in light purple in the bottom panel.

A limitation to the previous analysis is that many donors identify as non-partisan and that many donors are non-individuals, who cannot be matched to a major party registration.

¹⁴This figure is a funds-based analog to Conevska et al. (2026)'s APG. While I discuss values in this paper in terms of Democratic support, this value would be the same under terms of Republican support.

Furthermore, in cities where the vast majority of donors are from a single party, differences may be obfuscated by binary partisanship measures. In this subsection, I leverage the overlap in between municipal and congressional donors in order to recover the ideological bend of municipal donors. While imputed DW-NOMINATE is typically used in order to infer candidate ideology, in this section I interpret it as the ideological bend of a local candidate’s donor pool.

The top panel of Figure 2 finds that the distribution of candidates with more conservative donors and of candidates with more liberal donors overlaps substantially. Not only are most municipal candidates funded by contributors who mostly give to Democratic congressional candidates, but most races occur between two candidates with typically-liberal DW-NOMINATE scores.¹⁵

The bottom panel indicates that a candidate and their opponent are rarely supported by ideologically distinct donor pools. On average, the median within-contest difference in donor pools is equivalent to about 0.177 — similar to the Manchin–Collins DW-NOMINATE disparity (0.181). In light purple, I plot the distribution among state legislative pairings. Very rarely (11% of contests) do municipal contests reach the median level of ideological donor variation among state legislative candidates.

Does the latent dimension in cities correspond to partisanship or ideology?

A meaningful fact about federal and state elections is that the primary dimension underlying the structure of campaign contributions is ideological (e.g. Bonica, 2014). The previous sections have noted that there is substantial heterogeneity in the degree of partisan and ideological separation among donors by contest, though donors in local contests are typically much less separated than donors in the typical state legislature contest. However, it may be the case that while contributions within a contest are not dictated by ideological or partisan division, that the underlying structure governing donor preferences is still partisan

¹⁵While 0 is not particularly meaningful in DW-NOMINATE, it is indeed a threshold that tends to separate Democratic and Republican legislators.

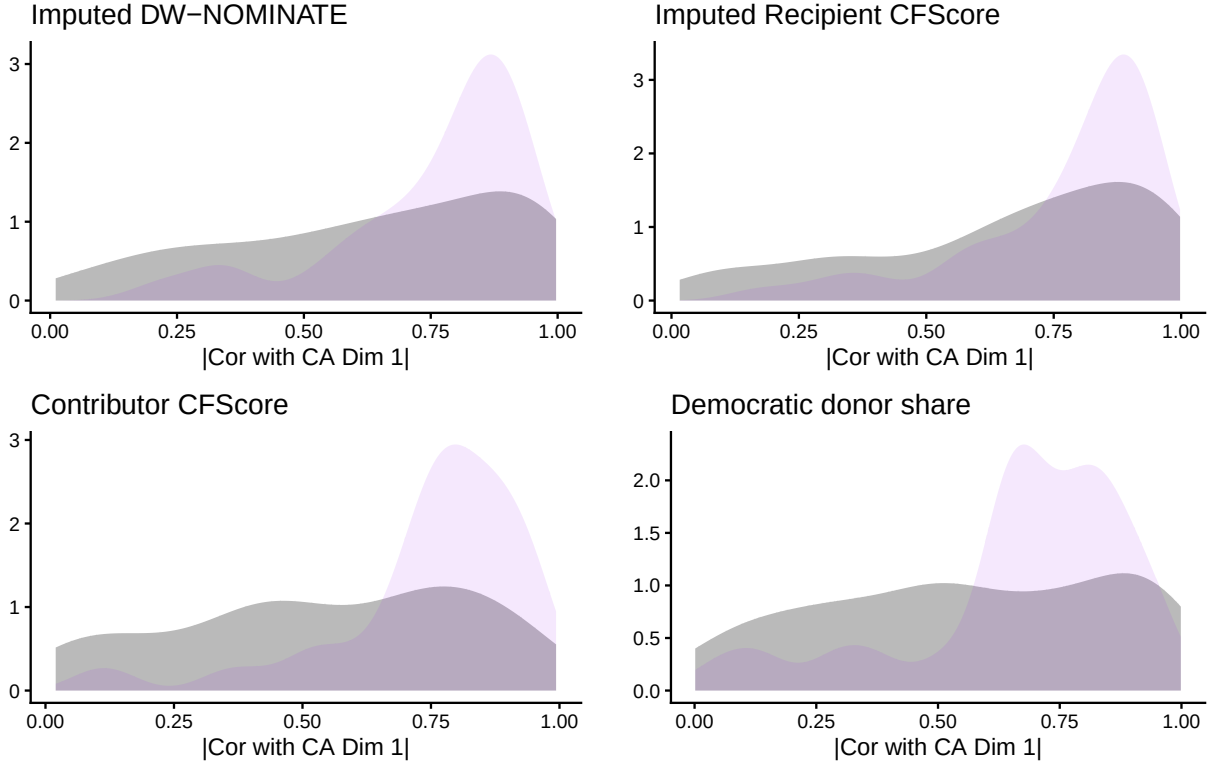


Figure 3 – Absolute correlations between the first latent dimension of the matrix of contributions within a city and various measures of candidate partisanship and ideology.

or ideological.¹⁶ This section considers this possibility.

In each panel of Figure 3, I consider the distribution of correlations between the first latent dimension of local campaign contributions (extracted via correspondence analysis) and various measures of candidate- and donor-based partisanship and ideology. In the top left panel, I consider the imputed DW-NOMINATE from Figure 2. The top right panel repeats the same procedure, benchmarking based on congressional CFScores instead of NOMINATE scores, since the relationship between these two scores are increasingly weak in the modern era (Barber, 2022). In the bottom left panel, I examine contributor CFScores — based how municipal candidates donate in state and federal elections. In the bottom right panel, I look at the Republican share of donors. In all panels, the corresponding state-level distribution is graphed in purple.

¹⁶For example, consider a case where donors only give to very close partisan matches, but the candidates in general elections are typically ideologically similar. Here, the latent dimension is related to partisanship, but the lack of within-election partisan separation obfuscates.

Within the state legislative data (purple), a state’s first dimension is typically highly correlated with measures of donor partisanship and ideology. Within the state data, the first dimension and measures of donor partisanship and ideology are quite correlated (with averages around or above 0.75 for all measures). However, city races (gray) are substantially more heterogeneous, with substantially more mass in the bottom half than its state legislative counterparts. Correlations at the city level average around or above 0.5 — smaller than the state legislature counterparts but still substantial.

As in past figures, the results indicate that there is substantial heterogeneity across cities. Electoral contributions in mid-size and large American cities are not uniformly defined by partisanship and ideology, but they are also not non-partisan and non-ideological in nature. The remaining sections examine possible sources of this heterogeneity.

Partisan competition

Some work suggests that formally partisan elections are a strong organizing force in local politics (Bucchianeri, 2020; Conevska et al., 2026; Dowling et al., 2025). The mechanisms underlying this finding are unclear. It may be because the places that hold partisan elections are systematically different than the cities that hold non-partisan elections. It may be because the presence of partisan labels induces partisan and ideological competition that might otherwise not exist. Or it may be that partisanship and ideology are of primary importance — and that the level of partisanship and ideological competition is low in intra-party races because there is little ideological differentiation and no partisan differentiation.

In this section, I first show that contests featuring inter-party competition are certainly more partisan- and ideologically-separated than contests featuring intra-partisan competition. This is true both when looking at within-contest competition and the latent structure of contributions within entire cities. Then, leveraging variation in partisan competition in formally non-partisan cities, I find support for the idea that partisanship and ideology are indeed of primary importance to donors when candidates represent different parties and are ideologically distinct.

Elections featuring partisan competition have somewhat higher levels of donor-based partisan and ideological dynamics

Figure 4 first considers the cross-sectional case. I show that ideological- and partisan-separated giving is substantially rarer when contests are in between two copartisan candidates. Under partisan competition, candidate differences in partisan backing and especially differences in ideological backing are much closer to levels from state legislative races.

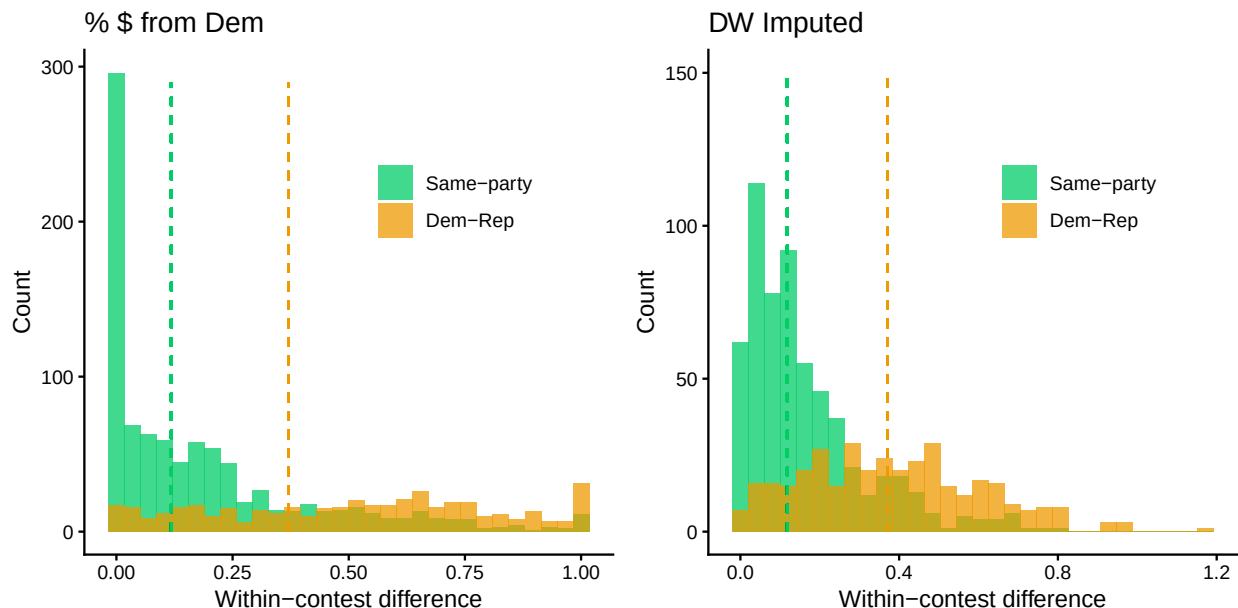


Figure 4 – Histograms of within-contest differences in the percent of funds from Democrats and imputed DW-NOMINATE scores. Differences are substantially smaller in the absence of partisan competition.

In Figure 5, I repeat Figure 3, instead comparing the 39 cities where at least 75% of contests are inter-partisan (orange) to 61 cities where at most 25% of contests are inter-partisan (green). Two different distributions emerge. In cities where competition is mostly between Democrats and Republicans, correlations in between the first correspondence analysis dimension and various measures of ideology and partisanship are quite strong (though somewhat weaker than the state legislative analogs), with peaks close to one. When competition is frequently between candidates originating from different parties, partisanship and ideology are frequently the basis for campaign contributions in local elections. When competition is in between members of the same party, the first latent dimension of local contributions are

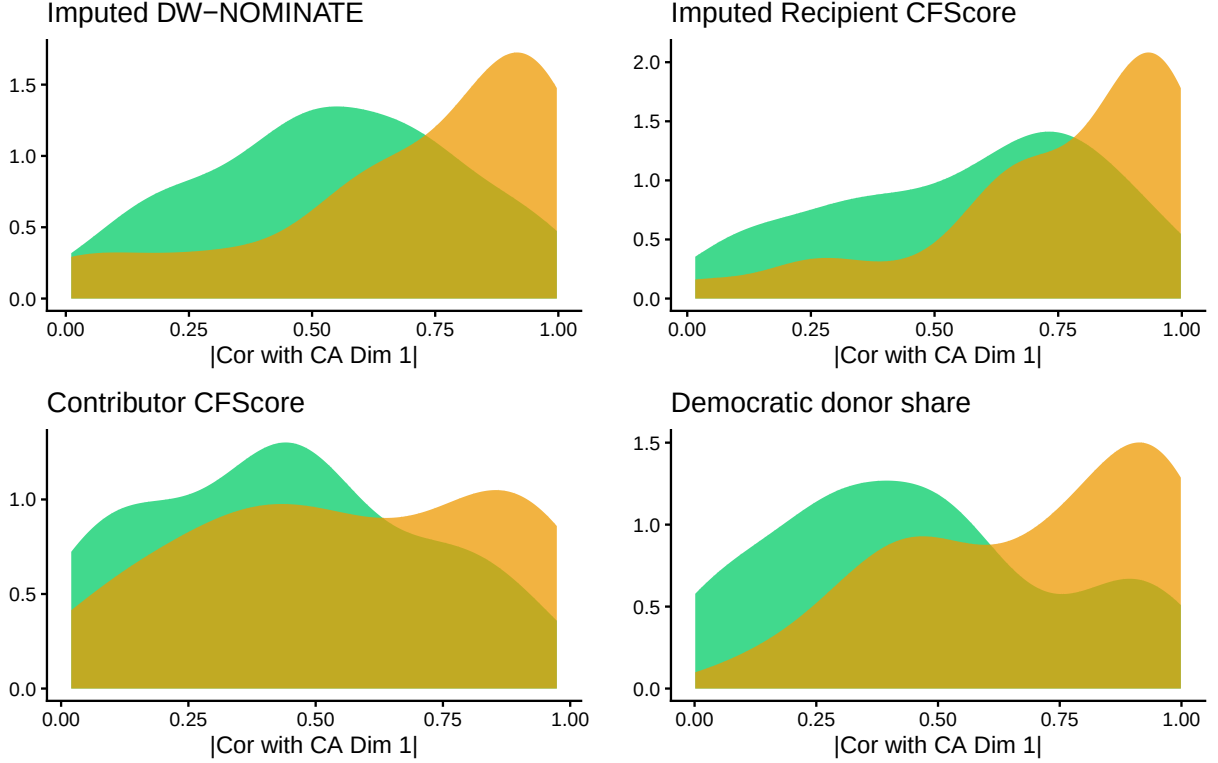


Figure 5 – City-wide correlations between the first latent dimension of contributions and measures of partisan and ideology, subset only to cities that frequently ($\geq 75\%$, in orange) and infrequently ($\leq 25\%$, in green) feature partisan electoral competition.

less likely to reflect partisan and ideological division.

In the cross-sectional data, the partisan structure of contributions seems contingent on the presence of partisan competition. But even in cities with frequent partisan competition and in contests featuring partisan competition, partisan separation is lower in local races than in federal races. In the rest of the paper, I focus on two follow up analyses. First, do the previous differences emerge **because** of partisan competition? In other words, does inter-partisan competition itself, instead of the city-wide factors that make inter-partisan competition more or less likely to emerge (such as city demographics or election systems), explain why the dynamics of some contests are more partisan? The second focuses on how interest-based groups structure contributions in local elections, and assess whether local interests constrain partisan giving.

Candidate-based partisan and ideological divides structure partisan and ideological giving

Previous studies and the previous results cannot differentiate between the possibility that formally partisan elections (and everything bundled alongside this policy choice) are necessary for high levels of partisan and ideological separation among individuals, or the possibility that the mere presence of partisan competition or ideology-gaps between candidates alone incites separating behavior. In Table 2, I consider donor separation along partisan and ideological lines when the partisan and ideological similarity between C_1 and C_2 vary, holding city fixed.

	D-R separation		Imputed DW difference	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Partisan competition	0.142 (0.018)		0.176 (0.013)	
Contrib CF difference		0.207 (0.024)		0.188 (0.016)
Municipality FE	X	X	X	X
N	1247	533	948	421

Table 2 – When local races feature partisan and ideological competition, electoral dynamics become substantially more partisan and ideological in nature, even when holding city fixed. Standard errors clustered by city.

When races feature partisan competition, donor pools are associated with higher levels of both partisan-based separation (column 1) and imputed DW-NOMINATE score-based separation (column 3). When compared to values from Figure 4, the coefficients from columns 1 and 3 of Table 2 account for over half of the observed cross-sectional difference between donor behavior under same-party and opposite-party competitors. This finding is congruent with the idea that donors are highly motivated by partisanship in local elections, even in cities with systems specifically designed to lessen the importance of partisanship.

Columns 2 and 4 show that when the absolute gap between Contributor CFScores scores from candidates gets larger, donors also become more separated along partisan and ideological lines. A 1-point difference in Contributor CFScores is about the difference between

the congressional Democrat (or Republican) with the most liberal and moderate donating patterns, so a full point is typically only spanned in inter-party competitive situations. Appendix Table 6 considers only intra-party competition and recovers a smaller (reduced by about 25–33%) coefficient, indicating that this effect is not simply an artifact of inter-partisan setups. Appendix Table 6 also breaks down the Contributor CFScore results by quartile, and finds that this relationship is non-linear: larger Contributor CFScore gaps yield much bigger differences.

Appendix Table 7 considers that conditioning on who gives at the federal and state level might bias results upward, since these candidates are inherently interested enough in state and federal politics to contribute money. While I cannot observe the ideological preferences of non-givers, I can repeat the first two columns using only contests where at least one candidate is not matched to a Contributor CFScore, indicating that the candidates within these contests are less interested in polarized politics. Coefficients in Appendix Table 7 are similar to those in Table 2.

The coefficients from Table 2 (and the following Table 3 and Appendix Tables 6–7) should be interpreted with caution. A causal interpretation would require that within a given city, the contests where partisan and ideological competition emerges are random, and not systematically different from contests where competition is not partisan — an evaluation that I currently lack the data to assess.¹⁷ I cannot conclude that partisan and ideological competition *causes* donors to separate on partisan and ideological lines. However, it is clear that the presence of partisan and ideological competition is associated with higher levels of partisan and ideological separation by donors.

Figure 6 reveals that one very strong reason for the lack of partisan and ideological behavior among donors within the overall distribution is that within-contest, C_1 and C_2 are both frequently co-partisans and ideologically similar. Within my data, only about 39% of contests feature partisan competition. Dropping cities with formally partisan elections (who by definition must always feature partisan contest), this figure drops to 37%. When candidates are similar along ideological and partisan lines, the structure of elections cannot

¹⁷To my knowledge, there are no datasets outlining local primary results.

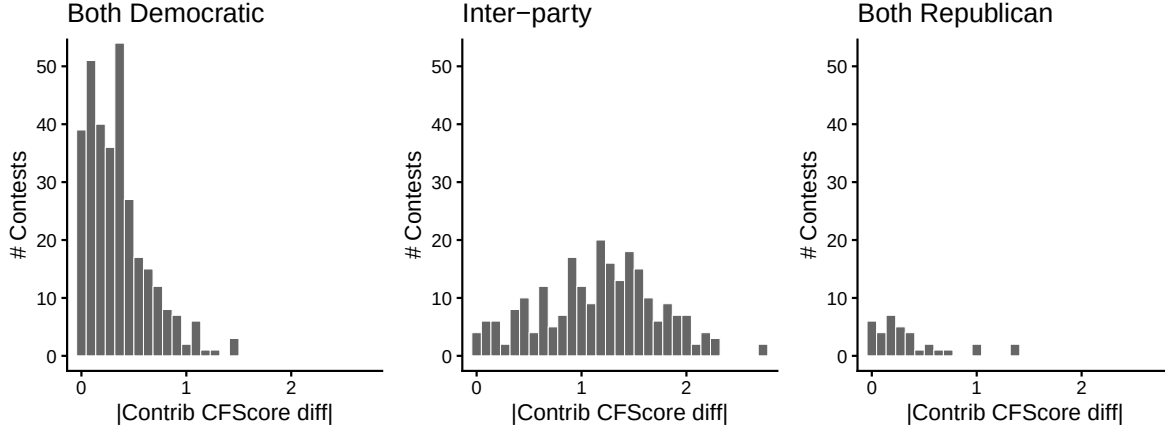


Figure 6 – The majority of local contests feature two ideologically-similar and partisan-matched candidates.

come from partisanship and ideology. In the following section, I consider the balance of donors’ occupation-based interests and partisan interests.

Does partisanship overrule local interests?

While inter-partisan elections hold substantial explanatory power, Figure 4 shows substantial heterogeneity in within-contest partisan and imputed DW-NOMINATE donor differences even when contests are inter-party. Even in inter-party elections, the partisan split, at about 0.35, is substantially lower than the almost 0.7 in state legislatures.

This section considers that local interests might play a role in tempering the effects of partisanship. To measure the partisan interest signals that donors experience, I aggregate contributions by donor employment-industry groups and by donor partisanship. While some work derives interest signal via the contributory patterns of corporations, unions, and interest groups themselves (instead of including contributions from their members) (Anzia, 2022; Carreri et al., 2025), doing so substantially limits the observability of an interest’s financial reach.¹⁸ To first show that employment-based interests are highly unified, I run a regression at the contest-group level, with contest fixed effects. Group unity (the extent to which donors within a given group all side with a single candidate, ranging from .5 to 1) is the dependent

¹⁸Cities, even in red states, often have contribution limits, impeding substantial sums of money to flow from an organization alone without member mobilization.

variable, with group serving as the independent variable. Contest fixed effects difference out overall rates of financial imbalance between C_1 and C_2 within a contest. Figure 7 shows rates of group unity (above baseline election levels) for members of local interests and parties.

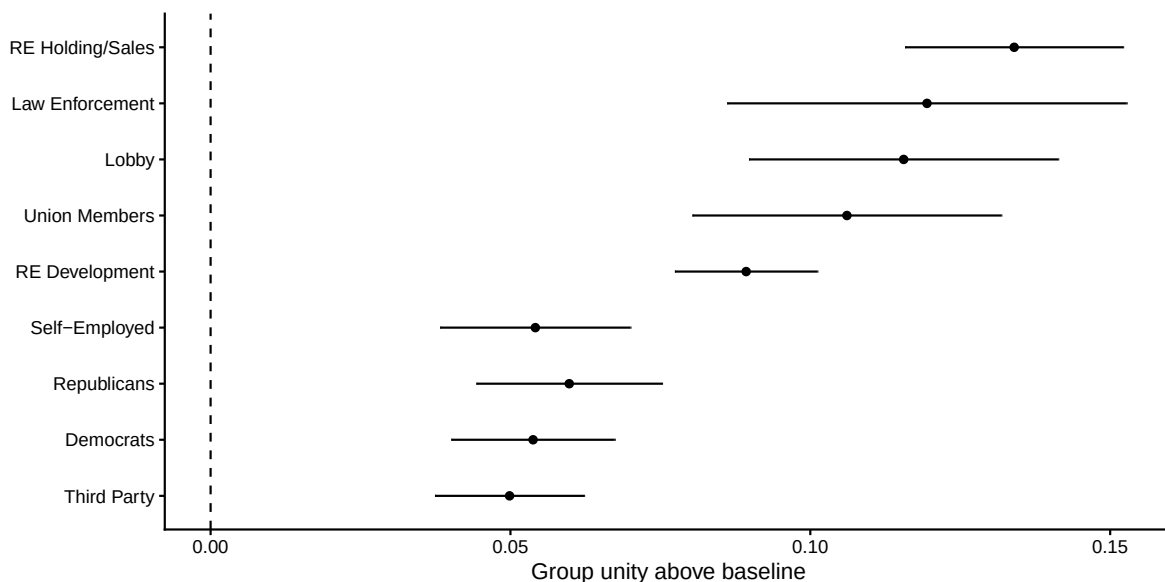


Figure 7 – Within-contest, unity within employment-based coalitions is often stronger than unity in party-based coalitions. In all listed cases, information about occupation party is informative on candidate preference. I require that there are at least 5 donors within each group within a contest, and Appendix Figure 10 varies mandated group size. Standard errors are clustered by city.

The results in Figure 7 show high levels of unified giving within several employment-based industries. To interpret coefficients, individuals involved in real estate renting and sales are about 13% (pp) more unified in their contributory behavior than average (the baseline is the overall distributional average). While this coefficient seems small, it is limited by the upper bound. Since most local elections are not particularly financially competitive (both the mean and median level of financial unity across the whole population is around 80%), this indicates that non-developmental real estate’s preferred candidate typically receives around 93% of funds from individuals occupied in the industry.

There are two important facts to draw from Figure 7’s finding that people employed in local interests are particularly unified, even after accounting for the overall imbalance of funds within a given election. First, the fact that employment-based groups are very highly unified within the same industries that have been hypothesized to exert outsized influence

in local elections validates the method of looking to employee behavior as a signal.

Second, most groupings of listed interests are more financially cohesive than partisan groupings. Descriptively, this is consistent with the possibility that local interests are a strong force in the organization of campaign contributions, and also consistent with the possibility that interests actually curb the role of partisanship in local elections.

Group unity, party unity, and partisan competition

In order to investigate the possibility that the strength of local interests act as a counter-balance to partisan behavior in local elections, I consider the relationship in between party and group unity, the presence of partisan competition, and preferences over candidates. I compare the importance of group unity signals to individual-level decisions over C_1 and C_2 in the presence of inter- and intra-partisan competition.

	Probability prefer Candidate 1				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Group unity x No PC	0.629 (0.040)	0.643 (0.046)	0.702 (0.088)	0.648 (0.048)	0.631 (0.036)
Party unity x No PC	0.362 (0.047)	0.464 (0.062)	0.565 (0.119)	0.394 (0.066)	0.357 (0.042)
Group unity x PC	0.219 (0.056)	0.346 (0.047)	0.364 (0.152)	0.215 (0.049)	0.279 (0.050)
Party unity x PC	0.807 (0.046)	0.868 (0.037)	0.949 (0.077)	0.840 (0.038)	0.759 (0.052)
Municipality FE	X	X	X	X	X
Party FE	X	X	X	X	X
Subset	Financially comp Party/group diverge Open seats Indep avgs				
N	96842	53166	19718	45214	60658

Table 3 – Higher values indicate a positive relationship in between group or party unity and the probability of giving to a candidate. As in Figure 7, I subset to match-ups with at least five donors from an industry. Standard errors clustered by city and industry.

Table 3’s Column 1 considers all individuals where occupation, individual partisanship, and candidate partisanship are known. I subset to occupations where at least five donors give within a contest, and exclude catch-all categories including unemployed, uncategorizable, and retired individuals. For each contribution i , group and party unity are calculated by leaving information from i out, so that these values are not biased by an individual’s own behavior.

The first two rows indicate behavior when partisan competition is absent. In these situations, group unity is typically more informative of a donor’s preference over C_1 and C_2 than party unity. The final two rows show how these values change in the wake of partisan competition. The signal from group unity becomes substantially weaker, and the signal from party unity becomes substantially stronger.

Subsequent columns subset to at-least nominally financially competitive races (races where no candidate raises over 75% of funds) in column 2, instances where the preferences of a contributor’s own party and group diverge (column 3), and situations where there is no incumbent in the race (column 4). Throughout previous columns, an individual’s group and party signals (independent variables) are created using other individuals’ dependent variables. Column 5 removes this potential circularity issue by creating group and party preferences using a 1/3 subset of the data, and withholds these observations from the regression. The findings are remarkably similar. When partisan competition is absent, group unity is more informative of an individual’s preferences. When partisan competition is present, party unity better predicts a donor’s choice of candidate than does group unity.

Appendix Table 5 considers four interests theorized to be especially strong and influential within local politics: real estate, unions, police/fire, and other local government employees (excluding education), and subsets only to individuals within these groupings. Real estate, union, and local government employees reflect the same trends as shown in Table 3. A notable exception are individuals employed in fire/police departments: even under partisan competition, group unity’s coefficient is larger than party unity’s coefficient. However, under all employment groupings, partisan competition is associated with substantially smaller group unity coefficient. These results underscore the same common finding occurring throughout the rest of this paper: when partisan competition occurs, contributions are structured in a partisan manner. Under the majority of cases without partisan competition, separate factors such as group interests dominate contributory behavior.

Conclusion

Local elections and politics are often characterized as distinctive from the nationalized, partisan nature of state and federal politics. At the same time, partisanship seems to hold explanatory power in both vote choice and in the policy preferences of elected officials.

In this paper, I reconcile these two views by clarifying when, and to what extent partisanship shapes individual electoral behavior. I use campaign contributions from mid-sized and large cities to document the partisan and ideological nature of local campaign contributions. Relative to campaign contributions at the state level, contributions at the local level are less separated by donor partisanship and donor ideology. Donors tend to give to candidates preferred by their occupation industry more than they do to candidates preferred by their copartisans. These findings are consistent with a view of local distinctiveness.

I find substantial heterogeneity by contest and by city. Some contests see high separation according to donor partisanship and ideology. In some cities, the underlying structure of contributions is well-correlated with measures of partisanship and ideology. Leveraging variation in by-contest partisan competition, I find that when partisan competition is present, the structure of elections is much more ideological and partisan, and contributions are more structured by individual-level partisanship than occupation industry. In short, under partisan competition, donor behavior is structured along partisan and ideological lines.

Though partisan competition is associated with partisan and ideological behavior, partisan competition is not the norm. This leaves non-partisan and non-ideological dynamics to dictate the structure of campaign contributions in the majority of instances.

An important limitation to the current design has to do with the emergence of partisan competition. Within a city, I am unable to document why partisan competition emerges in some contests and not others. Nor can I assess whether the public nature of competition differs. For example, it is unclear whether inter-party competitors in formally nonpartisan cities latch to national politics in their appeals to voters.

Furthermore, the nature of the underlying dataset on campaign contributions in local elections limits the inferences that can be drawn. This work only considers behavior in mid-

sized and large cities. Given that personal networks are tighter within smaller cities and city budgets are smaller, valence and personal relationships may matter even more as city size decreases, possibly also at the expense of partisanship. Additionally, the series of merges required to assemble the datasets used in this paper are a source of missing data and error.

These results contribute to the debate over the level to which local elections (as well as local policy) have nationalized, highlighting that the extent to which we are able to observe partisan and ideological behavior is structured by the balance of candidates. At the federal and state level, general election competition is typically between two candidates with distinct partisan and ideological attributes. Local elections differ: competition is typically intra-partisan. The results from this paper also encourage new ways to clarify results surrounding this debate: are candidate speech and policy proposals more nationally-oriented under partisan competition? Have these dynamics shifted over time? Do these results hold under other contest types and in smaller cities? Further examination of within-city, cross-city, over-time dynamics can help clarify the conditions under which local politics are both distinct and nationalized.

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1 Appendix

1.1 Employment sorting

Industry	N	Industry	N	Industry	N
RETIRED	116192	CREATIVE	17367	UNION	6992
LAW	64961	CONSULTING	16526	HEALTH	5664
SELF	59456	PHYSICAL LABOR	14284	INSURANCE	5124
UNEMP	44079	PUB EDU	13809	LEO	4304
REAL ESTATE	36282	RE DEV	13040	TRAVEL	3919
OTHER ADMIN SALES	35765	EDU	12537	PAC	3185
LOCAL GVT	28576	STATE/FED	10134	RELIGION/NONPROFIT	2757
FINANCIAL	25802	LOBBY	9237	AUTO	1467
MEDICAL	25695	LANDLORD	7943		
STEM	24386	SERVICE	7861		

Table 4 – LEO includes fire employees. Local government excludes police/fire and education. Pub edu denotes K-12 workers, and edu includes other education workers (such as college professors). Union indicates individuals working for a union directly.

AUTO: NISSAN , LEXUS , AUDI , VOLKSWAGEN , CHEVY , MAZDA , CHEVROLET , FORD , CADILLAC , HONDA , TOYOTA , AUTOMOTIVE , CAR DEALER , AUTO DEALER
CONSULTING: BAIN, PWC, BOOZ , MCKINSEY, DELOITTE, ACCENTURE, CONSULT
CREATIVE: EDITOR, DESIGN , DESIGNER , ACTRESS, ACTOR, PRODUCER , MUSICIAN , FILM , JOURNALIST , COLUMNIST , LITERARY , THEATER , THEATRE , TELEVISION , PHOTOGRAPH , PHOTO , GRAPHIC, PUBLISHER, BROADCAST, ARTIST , WRITER
EDU: COLLEGE, U OF , LECTURER, FACULTY, PROFESSOR, EDUCATION, UNIVERSITY, UNIV , **INSURANCE:** CLAIMS , CLAIM , BCBS , INSURANCE , ACTUAR, INSURANCE , ADJUSTER , CLAIMS , INSURANCE
LANDLORD: PROPERTIES , LANDLADY , LANDLORD , RENTALS , PROPERTY
LAW: DICKINSON WRIGHT, HARBISON, COUNSEL , XLLP , LEGAL, COURT CLERK , LAW CLERK , LAWYER, ARBITRATION, PARALEGAL, ASSOCIATE, ATTY , ATTORNEY, LAW
LEO: NYPD, CORRECTION, FIRE, POLICE, FIRE, POLICE, LAW ENFORCE
LOBBY: LOBBY, PR , GOVERNMENT RELATION, GOVERNMENT AFFAIR, AFFAIRS , GOVT AFFAIR, GOVT RELATION, PUBLIC AFFAIR, PUBLIC RELATION, ACTIVIST
LOCAL GVT: TRAIN , BUS , HUMAN SERVICES, ELECTIONS, CCSF, PUBLIC SECTOR, LIBRARY, COUNTY , MAYOR, COMMISSIONER, ASSEMBLY , CITY , COUNCIL, CANDIDATE, TRASH , UTILITIES , METRO , GOVERNMENT
MEDICAL: SOCIAL WORK, HEALTH , HEALTHCARE, DDS , MD , DOCTOR , OPTOMETRIST , DIETITIAN , DIALYSIS , CLINICAL , CLINIC , HOSPITAL , SURGEON , PHARMACY , GYNCOLO, DENTAL , PHARMACIST , THERAPIST , PARAMEDIC , NURSE , MEDICAL , OLOGIST, SURGICAL , DENTIST , PHYSICIAN , RN , MEDICAL
OTHER ADMIN SALES: ADMINISTATIVE ASS, ADMIN ASS, RECEPTIONIST, HUMAN RESOU, SECRETARY , AS-SURANCE , RECRUIT, CUSTOMER , SERVICE , MARKETING , ANALYST , SALESP, SALESMAN , SUPERVISOR , MANAGER , SALES , ADMINISTR, MANAGEMENT , MANAGER
PHYSICAL LABOR: HVAC , ROOFING , HANDYMAN , SANITATION , FARM , GUARD , WELDER , MECHANIC , ELECTRICIAN, GENERAL CONTRACTOR , STEAMFIT, COOLING , HEATING , LANDSCAP, PEST , ELECTRICAL , CONSTRUCTION , PLUMBING , PLUMBER , CARPENTER
PUB EDU: EDUCAT, INSTRUCTOR, DOE , SCHOO, TEACHER
RE DEV: BUILDERS , HOMEBUILDER, BUILDER , DEVELOPMENT , DEV , DEVELOPER
REAL ESTATE: REMAX , LAND USE, PROPERTY MANAGER , ARCHITECT, URBAN PLAN, HOMES , ESCROW , MORTGAGE , REALESTATE, HOMES , HOMES , REALTY, REALTOR, REAL ESTATE
RELIGION/NONPROFIT: CATHOLIC , CHURCH , PRAYER , DIOCESE , MINISTER , PRIEST , RABBI , NON-PROFIT, NON PROFIT
RETIRED: RETIRED
SELF: SELF , OWNER , SELF
SERVICE: JEWELER, SHIPPING , WAITER, WAITRESS, BARTENDER , CASHIER , RESTAURANT, STYLIST , RE-TAIL , SERVER , TAXI , TOWING , DRIVER , BARISTA , COOK , CHEF/, CHEF

STATE/FED: ARMED SERV, POSTAL , STATE , USPS, CONGRESS, LEGISLATOR , SENATOR , IRS , TSA , ARMY , STATE OF , BUREAU OF LAND MANAGEMENT , MILITARY , STATES DEPARTMENT OF , LEGISLATIVE , LEGISLATURE , STATES DEPARTMENT OF
STEM: APPLE, IT , PROGRAMMER, ENGINEER, FACEBOOK, NORTHROP, VERIZON, IBM, BOEING, GOOGLE, MICROSOFT, INTEL, AMAZON, ENGINEER , SCIENTIST , SOFTWARE
TRAVEL: AIRLINE, PILOT, TRAVEL , HOTEL
UNEMP: MOTHER , STAY AT , MOM , NA , NOT EMPLOYED , STUDENT , UNEMP, STAY AT , VOLUNTEER , HOUSE WIFE , HOUSEWIFE , HOME MAKER , DISAB, HOMEMAKER , UN EMP, NOT EMP, STUDENT
UNION: LIUNA , IBEW , DC1707 , ORGANIZER , REP , UNION , SEIU , IBEW , UNION , LOCAL , LABOR

1.2 Basic dataset attributes

Included cities

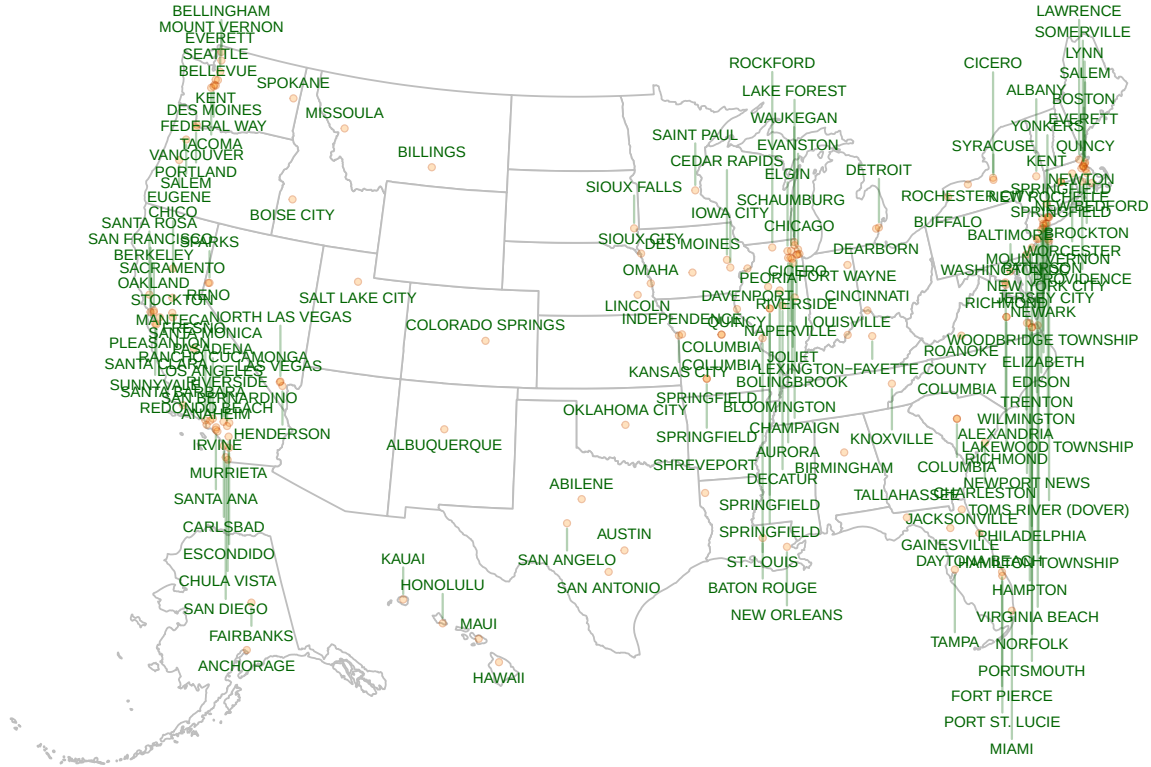


Figure 8 – Map of cities used

AK: FAIRBANKS CITY OF, ANCHORAGE CITY AND BOROUGH, FAIRBANKS NORTHSTAR BOROUGH
AL: BIRMINGHAM
CA: LOS ANGELES, SUNNYVALE, STOCKTON, SANTA ANA, SANTA ROSA, SANTA CLARA, SANTA BARBARA, SAN BERNARDINO, SAN FRANCISCO, SAN DIEGO, SACRAMENTO, RIVERSIDE, RANCHO CUCAMONGA, PASADENA, OAKLAND, MURRIETA, IRVINE, FRESNO, CHULA VISTA, CHICO, CARLSBAD, BERKELEY, ANAHEIM, REDONDO BEACH, PLEASANTON, MANTECA, ESCONDIDO, SANTA MONICA, LAKE FOREST, RICHMOND
CO: COLORADO SPRINGS
DC: WASHINGTON DC
DE: WILMINGTON
FL: MIAMI, JACKSONVILLE, GAINESVILLE, TAMPA, TALLAHASSEE, FORT PIERCE, PORT ST LUCIE, DAYTONA BEACH
HI: HAWAII, HONOLULU, KAUAI, MAUI
IA: IOWA CITY, CEDAR RAPIDS, DES MOINES, DAVENPORT, SIOUX CITY
ID: BOISE
IL: PEORIA, AURORA, CICERO, WAUKEGAN, ROCKFORD, EVANSTON, DECATUR, CHICAGO, NAPERVILLE, SPRINGFIELD, BLOOMINGTON, JOLIET, CHAMPAIGN, SCHAUMBURG, ELGIN, BOLINGBROOK
IN: FORT WAYNE
KY: LEXINGTON, LOUISVILLE
LA: NEW ORLEANS, BATON ROUGE, SHREVEPORT
MA: BOSTON, WORCESTER, NEWTON, BROCKTON, LYNN, NEW BEDFORD, QUINCY, SOMERVILLE, LAWRENCE
MD: BALTIMORE

MI: DEARBORN, DETROIT
MN: SAINT PAUL
MO: COLUMBIA, SPRINGFIELD, KANSAS CITY, INDEPENDENCE, ST LOUIS
MT: BILLINGS, MISSOULA
NE: OMAHA, LINCOLN
NJ: EDISON, JERSEY CITY, NEWARK, HAMILTON TOWNSHIP, TOMS RIVER DOVER TWP, WOODBRIDGE TOWNSHIP, LAKEWOOD TOWNSHIP, PATERSON, TRENTON, ELIZABETH
NM: ALBUQUERQUE
NV: HENDERSON, LAS VEGAS, NORTH LAS VEGAS, RENO, SPARKS
NY: NEW YORK CITY, ROCHESTER CITY CITY, NEW ROCHELLE CITY, MOUNT VERNON CITY, YONKERS CITY, SYRACUSE CITY, BUFFALO CITY, ALBANY CITY
OH: CINCINNATI
OK: OKLAHOMA CITY
OR: EUGENE, PORTLAND, SALEM
PA: PHILADELPHIA
RI: PROVIDENCE
SC: CHARLESTON, COLUMBIA
SD: SIOUX FALLS
TN: KNOXVILLE
TX: AUSTIN, SAN ANGELO, ABILENE, SAN ANTONIO
UT: SALT LAKE CITY
VA: ROANOKE, VIRGINIA BEACH, HAMPTON, ALEXANDRIA, RICHMOND, NEWPORT NEWS, NORFOLK, PORTSMOUTH
WA: EVERETT, SEATTLE, KENT, VANCOUVER, FEDERAL WAY, TACOMA, SPOKANE, BELLEVUE, BELLINGHAM

Temporal variation

Year	Count	Year	Count	Year	Count
2004	11,694	2010	56,071	2016	85,750
2005	18,897	2011	112,055	2017	163,908
2006	32,753	2012	97,088	2018	103,616
2007	78,410	2013	159,545	2019	180,432
2008	54,717	2014	89,898	2020	100,419
2009	78,240	2015	159,257	2021	47,615

1.3 Local races are not just re-hashing national races

The federal-local overlap may also further indicate the extent to which nationally-minded donors dominate the local landscape. The vast majority of donors in local elections do not ever give federally, with only about 27.8% of local contributions ever matched to a congressional donor (far fewer within the same election cycle).

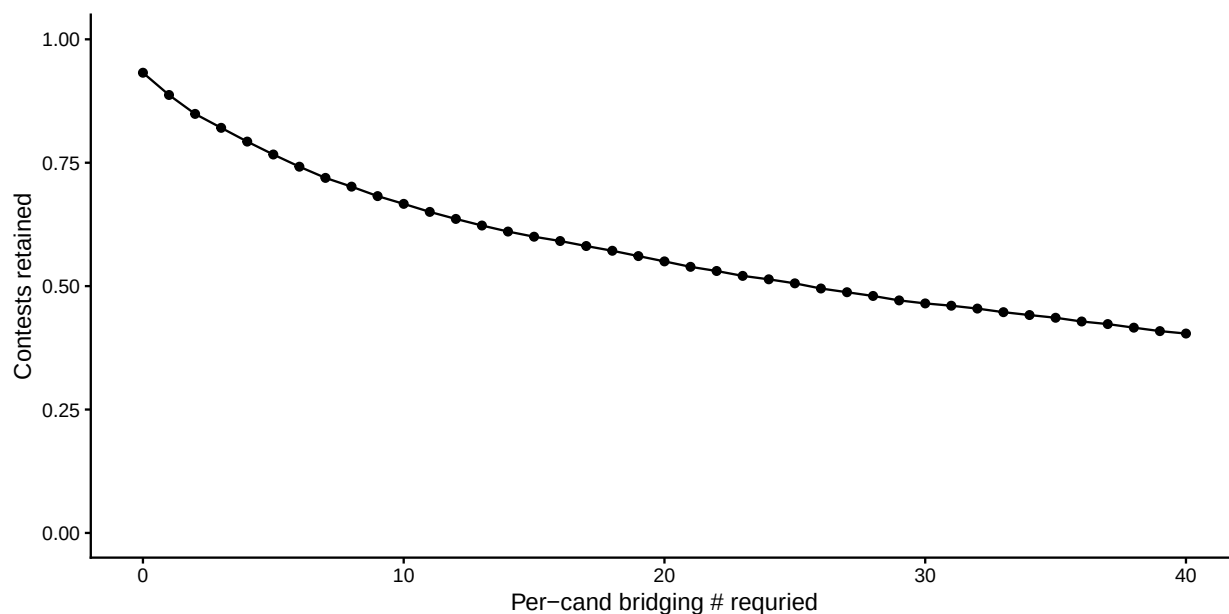


Figure 9 – Higher thresholds for the minimum number of overlapping donors greatly reduces the number of contests that can be used in analysis. Local races feature donors who overwhelmingly do not give at the federal level.

If local-federal donors are more ideological than the average local donor, then Figure 2 likely over-represents the true within-contest differences across the span of in-sample candidates. Candidates with imputed DW-NOMINATE scores are those who have an adequate amount of overlapping local-federal donors. In Figure 2 I require 5 or more overlapping donors per candidate, but increasing this requirement limits the proportion of contests used, as I show in Figure 9.

1.4 Results from Table 3 by industry and subtracting overall race unity

	Probability donate to Candidate 1				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Partisan competition					-0.087 (0.027)
Group unity x No PC	0.593 (0.081)	0.844 (0.080)	0.802 (0.071)	0.456 (0.041)	
Party unity x No PC	0.422 (0.082)	0.253 (0.109)	0.174 (0.059)	0.567 (0.042)	
Group unity x PC	0.334 (0.055)	0.388 (0.152)	0.617 (0.076)	0.072 (0.101)	
Party unity x PC	0.703 (0.045)	0.737 (0.158)	0.436 (0.129)	0.957 (0.102)	
Group - overall unity					0.660 (0.055)
Party - overall unity					0.368 (0.086)
Grp-overall x PC					-0.275 (0.080)
Party - overall x PC					0.481 (0.097)
Municipality FE	X	X	X	X	X
Party FE	X	X	X	X	X
Subset	Real Estate	Union	Police/Fire	Local gvt	
<i>N</i>	8564	1203	1134	8167	96842

Table 5 – Higher values = A group’s Democrats and Republicans converge on the same candidate.

1.5 Minimum group size and coefficients for Figure 7

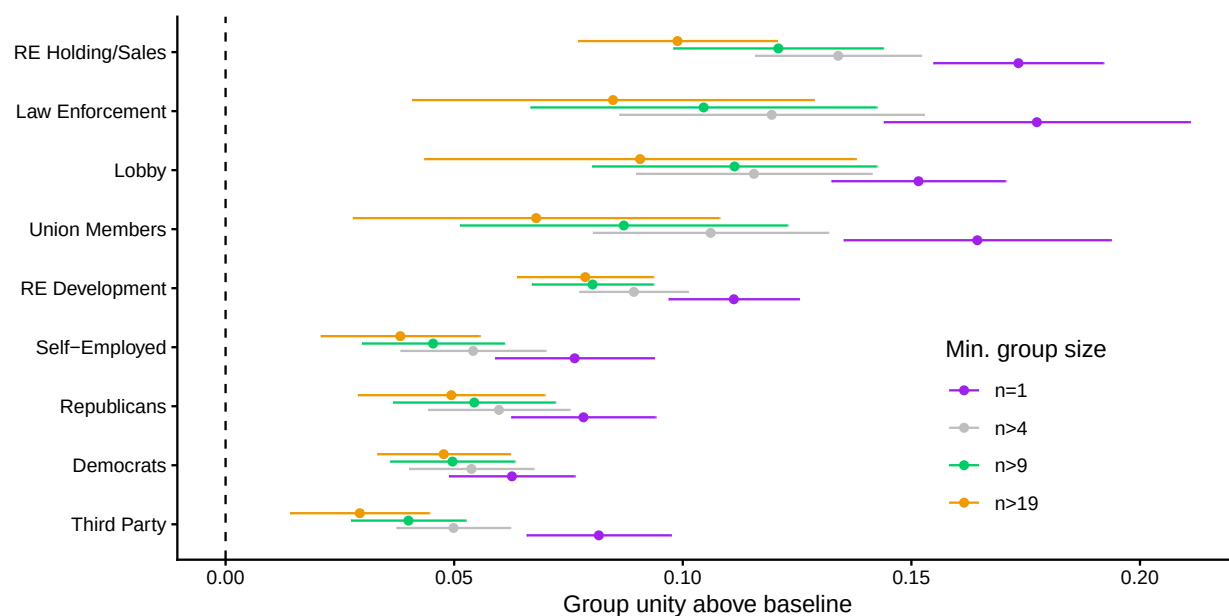


Figure 10 – Unity levels are somewhat the product of group size. The largest jumps occur between a minimum group size of 2 (group preferences are in practice not calculated when only one member is in a group) to 5. Despite the influence of minimum required group size on the coefficient, the statistical significance (against 0) as well as ordering are mostly consistent between groups.

1.6 Contributor CFScore differences in Table 2

	D-R separation		Imputed DW difference	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Contrib CF difference	0.108 (0.049)		0.117 (0.026)	
CF diff quartile 2		0.017 (0.032)		0.042 (0.021)
CF diff quartile 3		0.109 (0.034)		0.113 (0.022)
CF diff quartile 4		0.294 (0.038)		0.273 (0.025)
Municipality FE	X	X	X	X
Intra-party only	X		X	
<i>N</i>	297	533	245	421

Table 6 – The CFScore differences outlined in Table 2 are strongest when within-candidate CFScore differences are larger. One concern is that since one’s own party identification and CFScore are highly related, that this relationship is totally borne out of inter-party competition. Columns 1 and 3 consider only intra-party competition, and find smaller, albeit still-significant effects.

The first quartile contains absolute differences up to 0.2075. The lower thresholds for the third, and fourth quartiles are 0.4650 and 1.07. For matchups where both candidates have partisanship and CFScores matched, 90% of matchups in quartile 1 are intra-party. This figure is 89%, 56%, and 5% for the second, third, and fourth quartile, respectively.

1.7 Partisan differences in Table 2

	D-R separation	Imputed DW difference
	(1)	(2)
Partisan competition	0.122 (0.024)	0.157 (0.018)
Municipality FE	X	X
Races without CF diff	X	X
<i>N</i>	669	488

Table 7 – One concern is that the results from Table 2 are confounded by the presence of candidates who are entrenched in national politics, who might be more prone to bring national issues to local elections, who are more likely to have CFScores. I do not find strong evidence that this is the case: the point estimates in this table are slightly smaller, and not statistically distinct from the point estimates in Table 2.